

A GRAMMAR OF CONTEMPORARY LITERARY TAMIL

By

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Foreword

The International Institute of Tamil Studies is proud to publish '*A Grammar of Contemporary Literary Tamil*' by Prof. Pon. Kothandaraman popularly known as Portkō. It is a matter of pleasure to record here the fact that Prof. Portkō was on the staff of our Institute. As a scholar in traditional Tamil learning and modern linguistics, his contribution is noteworthy. His writings have thrown light on many aspects-now forgotten-of Tamil language and Literature, particularly in grammar.

The present book will surely add to the available material on this subject.

Prof. Portkō started teaching at Annamalai University and continued it at the SOAS of London University and visited State University of New York at Stony Brook and Northwestern University of U. S. A.

Later he was appointed a Visiting Profesor in the programme for a Comparative Study of Tamil and Japanese at Gakushuin University, TOKYO in 1990, 1993 and 1996. At present Dr. Portkō is Professor and Head of the Department of Tamil Literature, University of Madras.

Thus fully equipped, he has ventured to present grammar of Contemporary Literary Tamil.

The book is divided into six sections starting with phonemics and ending with morphophonemics, between them the entire grammatical structure of Tamil is discussed.

I am sure, this book is another feather in the author's cap and a real contribution to the study of Tamil Grammar.

We express our sincere thanks to Dr. M. Tamilkudimagan Hon'ble Minister for Tamil Official Language - Culture and Hindu Religious Endowment Board and Thiru. V. Palanichamy, I.A.S. Secretary for Tamil Development and culture Department for their constant encouragement given for the development of this Institute.

Our thanks are also due to PAVAI PRINTERS for printing the book neatly.

DIRECTOR.

Author's Preface

Tamil is one of the Dravidian languages which has a continuous history since the age of Tolkāppiyam, the earliest grammatical work available in Tamil (5th cent. B.C.). It is mainly spoken in the southern part of India, known as Tamil Nadu. It is also spoken in the other parts of India such as Pondicherry, Andaman & Nicobar Islands, Bangalore, Mysore, Hyderabad, Thiruvananthapuram, Mumbai, Calcutta, Delhi and Chandigarh. It is one of the official languages in Sri Lanka and Singapore. The Tamil speaking communities are found in the other countries such as Malaysia, Mauritius, South Africa, Fiji, Trinidad, Guyana, Maldives, Great Britain, France, USA, Canada and certain Arab countries.

Apart from India, the Tamil language is found to be in use in the mass-media of many other countries such as Singapore, Sri Lanka, Malaysia, UK and Canada. Tamil is included in the academic programmes in many universities at home and abroad. The area of the use of the Tamil language is fast expanding, especially in the latter half of the present century. Scholars of other speech communities increasingly show a keen interest in learning Tamil for various purposes. A good knowledge of Tamil is found to be indispensable for the study of Tamil Linguistics, Dravidian Linguistics, Tamil Literature, Saiva Siddanta, Indian History, Indian Culture, Current Politics in India and also the Indus Valley scripts.

In order to cater to the growing needs of the Tamil learners, a large amount of teaching materials have been produced in various centres of Tamil Studies. Although it is long felt that a concise dictionary in the bi-lingual format and a reasonable grammar for easy

5.3.11. Passive

A sentence which can be passivized must have a subject, an object and a transitive verb. But all the sentences which have a subject, an object and a transitive verb cannot be passivized. That is, certain sentences can be passivized and certain other sentences cannot be passivized.

Kaṇṇaṇ vaḷavaṇai aṭittāṇ - 'kannan beat valavan' can be passivized as *Vaḷavaṇ Kaṇṇaṇāl aṭikkappaṭṭāṇ* - 'Vallavan was beaten by kannan'. But, *nāṇ kaṇṇai viḷittēṇ* - 'I opened my eyes' cannot be passivized. Though there is a subject, an object and a transitive verb in this sentence, we cannot derive from this a passive sentence as * *kaṇ eṇṇāl viḷikkap paṭṭatu* - 'eyes were opened by me'.

When the thing meant by the object forms part of the thing meant by the subject in a sentence, that sentence cannot be passivized. In the sentence *nāṇ kaṇṇai viḷittēṇ* the object *kaṇ* forms part of what is meant by *nāṇ*, hence passivization is impossible. Besides this, *avaṇ tūkkam tūṇkiṇāṇ* - 'He slept a sleep' and *nāṇ avaṇ varuvataip pārttēṇ* - 'I saw him coming' do not have corresponding passive sentences. When there is a cognate object followed by its verb in a sentence, that sentence cannot be passivized. When the object of a sentence is an action nominal that sentence also cannot be passivized.

when we passivize a sentence the object of the active sentence becomes the subject of the passive sentence, the subject of the former one becomes the agent of the latter and the transitive verb undergoes certain changes.

Consider the following

118) *Pāṇṭiyaṇ Kōvalaṇaik Kōṇṇāṇ* + passive →

'Pandian killed kovalan'

Kōvalaṇ pāṇṭiyaṇāl kollappaṭṭāṇ -

'Kovalan was killed by Pandian.'

- 119) *Kaṇṇaṇ Vaḷavaṇaip pāṛāṭṭiṇāṇ + passive* →

'Kannan admired Valavan'

Vaḷavaṇ Kaṇṇaṇāl pāṛāṭṭappaṭṭāṇ -

'Valavan was admired by Kannan'

Passive is set up as an optimal item in the phrase structure. When it is selected we get passive sentences. In the case of the sentence (118) when the paassivization rule operates, the object *Kōvalaṇ* moves to the subject slot, the subject *pāṇṭiyaṇ* becomes an agentive being followed by 'āl' and the verb *Koṇṇrāṇ* changes into *Kollappaṭṭāṇ*. Similarly in the case of (119) the object *Vaḷavaṇ* moves to the subject slot, the subject *Kaṇṇaṇ* becomes an agentive being followed by *āl* and the verb *pāṛāṭṭiṇāṇ* changes into *pāṛāṭṭappaṭṭāṇ*. These facts might be summarized by the following rule.

Passivization rule

SD:	NP -	NP -	Obj.s -	X -	V -	Au _x -	Passive
	1	2	3	4	5	6	7
SC:	1....7	→	2	1 + āl	4 5 + inf + paṭu	6	

When 2 is other than a cognate object and an action nominal, and the thing meant by 2 does not form part of the thing meant by 1.

There are sentences in Tamil such as the following

- 120) *avaṇ enṇāl aṭipattāṇ*

'He got beating because of me'

- 121) *avaṇ enṇāl utai paṭṭāṇ*

'He got kicking because of me'

It must be borne in mind that they are not passive sentences. They cannot be traced to any other active sentence. The suffix 'āl' found in sentence (120) and (121) and the suffix 'āl' found in (118) and (119) are not one and the same. The former one is the causal 'āl' and the latter one is the instrumental or the agentive. So the sentences which can be analysed as NP - NP - āl - V - inf. - paṭu - Aux alone are passive sentences and the other sentences like (120) and (121) are just a kind of active sentences.